



Ming roof tile decorated with horse

Tile would have decorated the ridge of a roof.

Ming dynasty

In 1368, Hong Wu, a peasant who had led revolts against China's Mongol rulers, managed to drive the Mongols out and create a new dynasty, the Ming. He built a new capital at Beijing and established peace, prosperity, and good government. To make society more equal, he abolished slavery, confiscated big estates, gave land to the poor, and taxed the rich.

Admiral Zheng

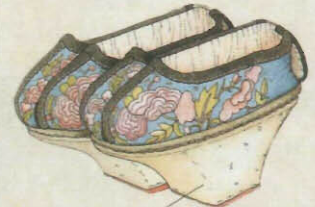
As part of the policy of restoring Chinese prestige, the Ming emperors sent Admiral Zheng He (1371–1433) to visit foreign rulers. Zheng made seven voyages in Southeast Asia and the Indian Ocean, sailing as far west as East Africa. He was accompanied by a fleet of 317 ocean-going junks.

Ocean-going junk

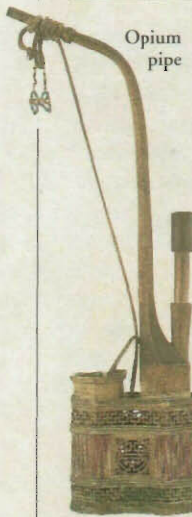


Foot binding

The Chinese believed that tiny feet were a vital part of female beauty. Young girls from rich families had their feet tightly bound to prevent them from growing. This process was very painful. Adult women were also forced to wear platform shoes. In 1902, the emperor issued an order banning foot binding, although it continued for many years.



Platform shoes made the wearer take tiny steps.



Opium pipe

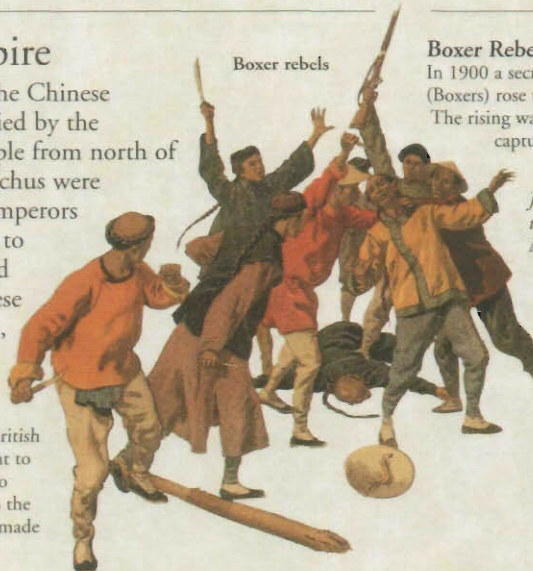
Decline of the empire

During the last 250 years of the Chinese empire, the throne was occupied by the Manchus, a non-Chinese people from north of the Great Wall. The first Manchus were enlightened rulers, but later emperors feared that change might lead to rebellion and they clung to old traditions. In 1911, the Chinese overthrew the feeble Manchus, and established a republic.

Opium wars

In 1839, the Chinese tried to stop the British opium trade in Canton. The British went to war, forcing the Chinese to open ports to foreign trade and to cede Hong Kong to the British. France, Russia, and later Japan, made similar demands.

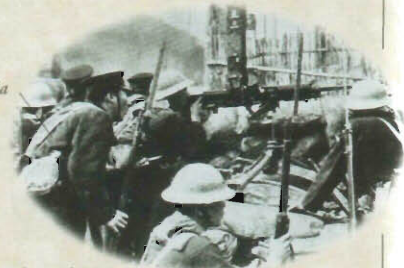
Boxer rebels



Boxer Rebellion

In 1900 a secret group called the Society of Harmonious Fists (Boxers) rose up in protest at European involvement in China. The rising was swiftly put down when an international force captured Beijing, but it weakened China's government.

Japanese troops in Manchuria



Japanese invasion

Civil war and a communist uprising weakened the new republican government. In 1931 the Japanese took advantage of the chaos to invade the northern province of Manchuria. Six years later they invaded the rest of China, capturing cities and ports.

Communist China

In 1949, the communist party led by Mao Zedong (1893–1976) finally took control of China after years of civil war. The new government nationalized industry and the land, and began a series of five-year plans to transform the country into a major industrial power.



Red star, symbol from the Communist Chinese flag

Modern China

After the death of Mao Zedong in 1976, the Chinese began to modernize their economy by introducing western ideas and technology. Central government control over the economy relaxed, and this led to an economic boom as new industries were established.

Tiananmen Square

In 1989, students took to the streets of Beijing demanding democratic reform. Many students occupied Tiananmen Square, Beijing. On 4 June, the army entered the square, killing more than 3,000 people. After the Tiananmen massacre the pro-democracy movement was ruthlessly suppressed.



Troops in Tiananmen Square

Timeline

c.1650–1027 BC Shang dynasty rules northern China; bronzeworking and writing are developed.

221 BC First Emperor, Qin Shi Huangdi, founds the Qin dynasty and unites the country.



Shang bronze halberd (dagger)

221 BC–AD 618 Great Wall of China built.

589–618 Short-lived Sui dynasty builds the Grand Canal linking major rivers.

618–906 Tang dynasty brings great prosperity to China; art and trade flourish.

960–1279 Industrial revolution occurs under the Song dynasty.

1279 Mongols under Kublai Khan conquer China; trade with Europe flourishes along the Silk Road.

1368–1644 Ming dynasty establishes China as world power.

1644–1911 Manchu dynasty.



Mao Zedong

1911 Chinese republic declared.

1949 Communists declare the People's Republic of China.

1966 Mao Zedong heads Cultural Revolution.

1997 Deng Xiaoping dies. Hong Kong handed back to China by the UK.

1999 Portugal hands back Macao to China.

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